

TOPIC 16

The Request for Proposal (RFP) for the project titled "E-commerce Platforms for Traditional Handicrafts from Southern Vietnam," written from the perspective of the "Technology in an Indigenous Context Project,".

Request for Proposal (RFP)

Project Title: E-commerce Platforms for Traditional Handicrafts from Southern Vietnam

RFP Reference Number: 16

Issuing Organization: Swin HCM - Vietnam

Geographic Focus: Traditional Handicraft Producing Communities in Southern Vietnam

Country: Socialist Republic of Vietnam

1. Preamble and Organizational Mandate

[Insert Full Legal Name of the Issuing Organization], hereinafter referred to as the "Organization," is dedicated to supporting the economic empowerment and cultural preservation of the diverse artisan communities producing traditional handicrafts in Southern Vietnam, particularly those of Indigenous and ethnic minority groups. Recognizing the significant role of these handicrafts in sustaining livelihoods, preserving cultural heritage, and transmitting traditional skills, the Organization seeks to leverage the power of e-commerce to expand market access for these artisans while adhering to the principles of the "Technology in an Indigenous Context Project."

Guided by the core tenets of the "Technology in an Indigenous Context Project," this RFP invites proposals from qualified Proponents to collaborate with us in developing and implementing culturally appropriate and community-managed e-commerce platforms for traditional handicrafts. This initiative prioritizes fair trade practices, community ownership, cultural authenticity, ethical representation, and the long-term sustainability of artisan livelihoods.

2. Project Vision, Objectives, and Expected Outcomes

2.1 Project Vision: To establish sustainable and community-controlled e-commerce platforms that provide equitable market access for traditional handicrafts from Southern Vietnam, directly benefiting the artisan communities, preserving cultural heritage, and promoting fair trade practices.

2.2 Project Objectives:

- **Development of User-Friendly E-commerce Platforms:** To design and develop one or more user-friendly, secure, and culturally appropriate e-commerce platforms accessible to both artisans and customers.

- **Community Ownership and Management:** To create platforms that can be effectively owned, managed, and sustained by the artisan communities or their representative organizations.
- **Fair Trade and Ethical Practices:** To integrate fair trade principles into the platform design and operation, ensuring equitable pricing, transparency, and direct benefits to the artisans.
- **Cultural Authenticity and Representation:** To ensure accurate and respectful representation of the handicrafts, their cultural origins, and the stories of the artisans.
- **Secure Payment and Logistics Integration:** To integrate secure online payment gateways and facilitate efficient and reliable logistics solutions for product delivery.
- **Capacity Building for Artisans:** To provide training and support to artisans in using the e-commerce platforms effectively, including product photography, listing creation, order management, and customer service.
- **Promotion and Marketing Support:** To develop and implement culturally sensitive online marketing strategies to promote the handicrafts and the platforms to a wider audience.
- **Adherence to Ethical and Cultural Protocols:** To ensure that all aspects of the project adhere to strict ethical guidelines and cultural protocols established in collaboration with the artisan communities.

2.3 Expected Outcomes:

- **Functional E-commerce Platforms:** User-friendly and secure online platforms showcasing traditional handicrafts from Southern Vietnam.
- **Community-Managed Platforms:** Platforms that can be effectively owned and managed by artisan communities.
- **Increased Market Access for Artisans:** Expanded reach to national and potentially international markets for traditional handicrafts.
- **Fair and Equitable Trade:** Improved income and economic benefits for artisan communities through direct sales.
- **Preservation of Cultural Heritage:** Increased awareness and appreciation of traditional crafts and their cultural significance.
- **Empowered Artisan Communities:** Enhanced digital literacy and business skills among artisan communities.
- **Sustainable E-commerce Ecosystem:** A long-term, viable online marketplace for traditional handicrafts.
- **Ethical and Culturally Sensitive Representation:** Accurate and respectful portrayal of handicrafts and artisan stories.

3. Detailed Scope of Work and Technical Specifications

The Proponent will be responsible for the complete execution of this project, encompassing the following phases and detailed technical specifications:

3.1 Phase 1: Community Consultation, Needs Assessment, and Platform Strategy

- **3.1.1 Comprehensive Community Engagement:** Conduct extensive and culturally sensitive consultations with diverse artisan communities across Southern Vietnam to understand their current market access challenges, digital literacy levels, specific needs and preferences for e-commerce platforms, existing organizational structures, and concerns related to online sales.
- **3.1.2 Detailed Needs Assessment:** Based on the community consultations, conduct a thorough needs assessment to identify the specific functionalities, features, and support mechanisms required for effective e-commerce platforms.
- **3.1.3 Collaborative Platform Strategy Development:** Work collaboratively with the Organization and artisan representatives to develop a comprehensive e-commerce platform strategy, including the number of platforms (potentially segmented by craft type or region), key features, user flows for artisans and customers, branding considerations, and long-term sustainability models.
- **3.1.4 Definition of Technical Requirements:** Define the technical requirements for the e-commerce platforms, including platform architecture, security features, payment gateway integration, logistics integration (e.g., integration with local shipping providers), multi-language support (Vietnamese and potentially others), and mobile responsiveness.
- **3.1.5 Fair Trade and Ethical Guidelines Integration:** Develop and integrate clear fair trade principles and ethical guidelines into the platform design and operational processes, including transparent pricing mechanisms, direct artisan payouts, and promotion of sustainable practices.

3.2 Phase 2: Platform Design and Development

- **3.2.1 User-Centered Design:** Design intuitive and user-friendly interfaces for both artisans (for product listing, order management, etc.) and customers (for browsing, purchasing, etc.), considering varying levels of digital literacy.
- **3.2.2 E-commerce Platform Development:** Develop robust and secure e-commerce platforms based on the defined technical requirements, utilizing appropriate technologies and adhering to best practices in web development and security.
- **3.2.3 Secure Payment Gateway Integration:** Integrate secure and reliable online payment gateways that are commonly used in Vietnam and are accessible to both local and potentially international customers.
- **3.2.4 Logistics and Shipping Integration:** Develop or integrate solutions for managing product shipping and logistics, potentially partnering with local shipping providers and offering various shipping options.
- **3.2.5 Multi-Language Support Implementation:** Implement multi-language support, prioritizing Vietnamese and potentially English or other relevant languages.
- **3.2.6 Mobile Responsiveness:** Ensure that the e-commerce platforms are fully responsive and accessible on various mobile devices.

3.3 Phase 3: Artisan Training and Onboarding

- **3.3.1 Development of Training Materials:** Create culturally appropriate and easy-to-understand training materials (e.g., guides, videos, FAQs) in relevant languages to train

artisans on how to use the e-commerce platforms effectively. Topics may include product photography, writing compelling product descriptions, creating listings, managing inventory, processing orders, and providing customer service.

- **3.3.2 Delivery of Training Workshops:** Conduct hands-on training workshops for artisan communities in Southern Vietnam, providing personalized support and addressing their specific needs and challenges.
- **3.3.3 Onboarding Support:** Provide ongoing support and guidance to artisans during the initial onboarding process to ensure they can successfully list their products and manage their online stores.

3.4 Phase 4: Platform Launch, Marketing, and Ongoing Support

- **3.4.1 Platform Launch and Promotion:** Assist the Organization in launching the e-commerce platforms to the target audience, developing culturally sensitive online marketing strategies to promote the handicrafts and the platforms.
- **3.4.2 Digital Marketing and Outreach:** Implement digital marketing campaigns utilizing social media, local online channels, and potentially collaborations with influencers or tourism platforms to increase visibility and drive traffic to the platforms.
- **3.4.3 Customer Support Mechanisms:** Establish clear customer support mechanisms for both artisans and customers, including FAQs, contact forms, and potentially live chat or phone support.
- **3.4.4 Platform Monitoring and Maintenance:** Provide ongoing monitoring and maintenance of the e-commerce platforms, ensuring security, stability, and optimal performance.

3.5 Phase 5: Community Ownership Transition and Sustainability Planning

- **3.5.1 Development of Community Management Guidelines:** Develop clear guidelines and protocols for the long-term ownership and management of the e-commerce platforms by the artisan communities or their representative organizations.
- **3.5.2 Knowledge Transfer for Platform Management:** Provide training and knowledge transfer to designated community members or organization staff on platform administration, content management, order processing, and basic technical support.
- **3.5.3 Development of a Sustainability Plan:** Collaborate with the Organization and artisan communities to develop a comprehensive plan for the long-term financial and operational sustainability of the e-commerce platforms, including strategies for revenue generation (e.g., commission-based models), ongoing maintenance, and community contributions.

4. Deliverables

The Proponent shall provide the following deliverables throughout the project lifecycle, adhering to the timelines and quality standards outlined in the project agreement:

- **Phase 1:** Comprehensive community consultation reports, a detailed needs assessment report, a collaborative e-commerce platform strategy document, defined technical requirements, integrated fair trade and ethical guidelines.
- **Phase 2:** User-centered design mockups and prototypes, fully functional e-commerce platforms (one or more as agreed), integrated secure payment gateways, integrated logistics and shipping solutions, implemented multi-language support, mobile-responsive design.
- **Phase 3:** Culturally appropriate training materials for artisans, records of delivered training workshops, artisan onboarding support documentation.
- **Phase 4:** Platform launch plan and execution support, implemented digital marketing campaigns, established customer support mechanisms, platform monitoring and maintenance reports.
- **Phase 5:** Community management guidelines, knowledge transfer documentation for platform management, a long-term sustainability plan for the e-commerce platforms.

5. Proposal Requirements and Submission Guidelines

Interested Proponents are required to submit a comprehensive proposal that adheres to the following structure and guidelines:

5.1 Proposal Structure

- **Executive Summary:** A concise overview of the proposal, highlighting the Proponent's understanding of the project objectives, their proposed e-commerce solutions, and their relevant experience, particularly in developing e-commerce platforms for marginalized communities and their commitment to ethical and fair trade practices.
- **Organizational Profile and Experience:** Detailed information about the Proponent organization, including its history, expertise in e-commerce development, user-centered design, secure payment integration, digital marketing, and experience working with community-based organizations, preferably those involved in traditional crafts or fair trade initiatives. Demonstrate a strong understanding of the socio-economic context of artisan communities in developing countries. Provide specific project examples and testimonials where possible.
- **Technical Approach and Methodology:** A detailed description of the proposed e-commerce platform architecture, technology stack, security measures, payment gateway and logistics integration strategies, and approach to ensuring scalability and maintainability. Clearly outline how the proposed platform will be user-friendly for artisans with varying levels of digital literacy.
- **Community Engagement and Collaboration Strategy:** A comprehensive and culturally sensitive strategy for engaging with the diverse artisan communities throughout all phases of the project. Detail the proposed consultation methods, communication protocols, mechanisms for incorporating community feedback into the platform design and functionality, and strategies for ensuring community ownership and long-term management.
- **Project Management Plan and Timeline:** A detailed project management plan, including clear timelines for each phase, key milestones, a comprehensive work

breakdown structure, roles and responsibilities of all team members, communication and reporting protocols, risk management strategies, and quality assurance procedures.

- **Budget and Financial Proposal:** A transparent and detailed breakdown of all project costs, including platform development, design, payment and logistics integration, training, marketing support, travel, and any other relevant expenses. Provide a clear payment schedule linked to the achievement of key deliverables.
- **Team Qualifications and Experience:** Detailed resumes or curriculum vitae of all key personnel who will be directly involved in the project, highlighting their specific expertise in e-commerce development, UX/UI design, community engagement, digital marketing, training, and project management. Clearly outline their roles and responsibilities within the project team.
- **References:** Contact information for at least three (3) relevant client references, with a strong preference for organizations or communities for whom similar e-commerce platforms have been successfully developed and implemented, particularly in the context of fair trade or support for marginalized artisans. Include a brief description of the project and the Proponent's role.
- **Statement of Compliance and Ethical Considerations:** A signed statement explicitly affirming the Proponent's understanding of and full compliance with all requirements outlined in this RFP, including a firm commitment to fair trade principles, ethical representation of artisans and their crafts, and community empowerment.
- **Sustainability Plan Approach:** A preliminary outline of the Proponent's approach to developing a long-term sustainability plan that enables the artisan communities to independently manage and maintain the e-commerce platforms.

5.2 Submission Guidelines

- Proposals must be submitted electronically in PDF format.
- The proposal must be written in clear, concise, and professional English.
- Proposals should be submitted via email to: Dr. Thomas Hang – nsam@swin.edu.au

6. Evaluation Criteria

Proposals will be evaluated based on the following weighted criteria:

- **Demonstrated Understanding of Socio-economic Context and Fair Trade Principles (30%):** Depth of understanding of the challenges faced by artisan communities in Southern Vietnam, commitment to fair trade practices, and experience in developing solutions that directly benefit marginalized producers. The quality and relevance of references will be heavily considered.
- **Technical Expertise and Innovation in E-commerce Development (30%):** Strength, feasibility, innovation, and user-friendliness of the proposed e-commerce platform architecture, technology stack, and features, particularly for users with varying levels of digital literacy. Experience with secure payment and logistics integration is crucial.
- **Community Engagement and Collaboration Strategy (20%):** Clarity, comprehensiveness, cultural sensitivity, and feasibility of the proposed strategy for

meaningful and sustained engagement with the diverse artisan communities throughout all phases of the project, ensuring community ownership and long-term management.

- **Project Management Plan and Timeline (10%):** Clarity, realism, efficiency, and completeness of the proposed project management plan, timelines, resource allocation, risk management strategies, and quality assurance procedures.
- **Budget and Value for Money (10%):** Reasonableness, transparency, and justification of the proposed budget in relation to the scope of work, technical complexity, and anticipated positive impact on the artisan communities.

7. Selection Process and Indicative Timeline

Following the proposal submission deadline, a dedicated evaluation committee, comprising representatives from the Organization, artisan community leaders, e-commerce experts, and potentially fair trade advocates, will conduct a thorough and rigorous review of all eligible proposals based on the evaluation criteria outlined above.

8. Contact Information for Inquiries

All inquiries and requests for clarification regarding this RFP must be submitted in writing via email to: Dr. Thomas Hang – nsam@swin.edu.au